

ATHLETIC CLUB IS BASQUE ONLY — FOR HOW LONG?

Athletic would rather be a struggling club with an identity than a successful club without one.

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For a greater part of its history, Athletic Club, based in Bilbao, has been a notable contender challenging the dominance of Real Madrid and Barcelona in Spanish football. Boasting 35 titles, it stands as the third-most successful club in Spain. However, only two of these honours have been secured since the

beginning of the 21st century.

The last league and Copa del Rey titles for Athletic date back to the 1983/84 season. As Barcelona and Real Madrid flexed their financial might, Athletic found itself trailing in the competition. In this century, the club has clinched only two Super Cups, achieved in 2014/15 and 2019/20. The closest Athletic came to continental glory was its runner-up finish in the Europa League during the 2011/12 season.

Athletic, along with Barcelona and Real Madrid, has never experienced the setback of relegation. Maintaining this record is a goal for every season. The city feels a sense of relief when the club crosses 40 points in the season.

According to Mikel Gonzalez, the club's sporting director, this marks a safeguard from any potential relegation.

While Athletic may not vie for titles as consistently now, it proudly maintains its distinctive identity. Unlike Barcelona and Real Madrid, Athletic hasn't changed its approach. The club continues to adhere to its unique philosophy of exclusively choosing players of Basque origin, considering it a badge of

